An Israeli politician later explained on US television:

> We want to have a Jewish state. We can absorb the Arabs, but then it won't be the same country. We want a Jewish state like the French have a French state.

By 1953 Israel had absorbed 300,000 Jews from Arab countries and insisted that those same Arab countries should find homes for the Palestinian refugees. Jordan allowed the Palestinian refugees to settle and become citizens of Jordan but other Arab states kept them in refugee camps near the borders with Israel. Most of the refugees themselves dreamt of 'the Return': they were Palestinians and they wanted to return to their homes in Palestine.

Some Palestinians migrated to other parts of the Middle East or the West. They became engineers, teachers, doctors or businessmen. A small number became very wealthy. But the vast majority of the refugees remained poor and unemployed. In their camps, they formed a ring of human misery round the borders of Israel. Crowded together, they became frustrated and bitter. It was from the camps that the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) recruited most of its members.

Key dates

Fatah set up: 1959

Formation of the PLO: 1964

Six-Day War: 1967

The origins of the PLO

Since the end of the first Arab–Israeli war in 1949, Palestinians had been crossing the border into Israel, often just to try and retrieve their property. Later, some of them carried out armed raids, sometimes killing the new Jewish 'owners' of their property. The Israeli Defence Force (IDF) retaliated forcefully. In 1959 a new group of Palestinian fighters emerged. Its name was Fatah, which comes from the Arabic initials of its name 'The Movement for the Liberation of Palestine'. When spelt backwards, the initials spell *fatah*, which is the Arabic word for 'victory'. Fatah's leader was Yasser Arafat and its goal was to create a Palestinian state.

Key term

Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO)
As well as leading the armed struggle to regain Palestine, the PLO provided many health and welfare services in the Palestinian refugee camps. The Red Crescent society, which set up and ran hospitals, was headed by Yasser Arafat's brother.

Five years later, in 1964, the **Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO)** was set up by Arab leaders meeting in Cairo (see page 72). The aim of the PLO was to unite all Palestinians in the struggle to win back their land. The largest group within the PLO was Fatah. From 1965 to 1967, Fatah carried out an increasing number of guerrilla attacks on Israel and was supported by the Arab states which bordered Israel, especially Syria. However, after the Six-Day War of 1967, things were to be very different for Fatah and the PLO as a whole.

Key question
Why was the Six-Day War a turning point for the Palestinians?

The impact of the Six-Day War 1967

Syria, Jordan and Egypt, which had provided vital support for the PLO, were weakened by their heavy losses in the war. At the same time, Egypt and Syria became far more concerned about the lands they had lost to Israel than about the Palestinian refugees. Many Palestinians were now convinced that they would have to fight for their homeland on their own. This was even more urgent now that all the original land of Palestine, including the West Bank and Gaza Strip, was under Israeli rule.